

PRE-ANALYSIS PLAN

Projected Patriotism and Its Determinants

Olgahan Çat ¹

1 Introduction

What shapes attitudes towards conflict refugees? A growing literature points out the events that cause displacement, which can be grouped as voluntary (economic migrants) and involuntary (conflict migrants), and the latter has been shown to elicit more positive attitudes than the former. Furthermore, the distinction between voluntary and involuntary migration is based on assumptions that need to be addressed. While involuntary migration is argued to attract more sympathy than voluntary migration, I argue that fleeing conflict events is not necessarily perceived as an involuntary act. One of the common themes found in anti-Ukrainian tweets consist of "criticisms of men fleeing Ukraine, such as posts calling Ukrainian men cowards,stemming from the Ukrainian government's decision to bar men between the ages of 18–60 from leaving Ukraine" (Gruzd, Mai and Taleb, 2024), echoing sentiments similar to what their Syrian counterparts were facing (Rettberg and Gajjala, 2016). To explain when and how people perceive it as a voluntary act, I introduce the concept of patriotism called Projected Patriotism. People who embrace this notion expect citizens of other countries to act in patriotic ways and judge them accordingly, shaping their attitudes toward refugees. Employing survey experiments in the US and Turkey, I analyze how external factors such as military service, political elites' rhetorical use of refugees' impact on economy, security and culture, and internal attributes such as attachment to national symbolic values, and existing patriotic ideologies determine their Projected Patriotism levels.

1.1 Nationalism and Patriotism

Patriotism and nationalism are closely related yet distinct concepts, with nationalism often emphasizing exclusivist identity and superiority, sometimes fostering hostility toward outsiders (). Patriotism, on the other hand, typically reflects love for one's country and civic pride, emphasizing democratic values. While theorists have criticized patriotism for its exclusionary tendencies (Canovan, 2000; Gomberg, 1990; Sardoč, 2020; Nathanson, 2020), recent efforts have expanded its definition to include forms such as constitutional patriotism (Müller, 2006), moderate patriotism (Nathanson, 1989), and critical patri-

¹Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Government, the University of Texas at Austin

otism (Merry, 2009), among others (Schatz, Staub and Lavine, 1999). These approaches aim to define who qualifies as part of the patriotic community, what sacrifices are expected, and the conditions under which patriotic duties apply. Despite this expansion, the literature has yet to address whether citizens are expected to demonstrate patriotism for their own country in the eyes of foreign populations. This unexplored dimension, where failure to fulfill patriotic duties may signal disloyalty and influence attitudes toward marginalized groups such as refugees, introduces a new layer to discussions on patriotism (Arias and Blair, 2022).

Projected Patriotism highlights a novel moral argument that diverges from traditional objections to refugees based on economic, security, or cultural concerns (Salehyan and Gleditsch, 2006; ?). While such objections are often countered with factual corrections or emotional appeals, the notion that refugees fail morally by not staying to defend their homeland presents a unique challenge. This perception can fuel anti-refugee sentiment, making it essential to explore this concept to better understand how such attitudes form and how they might be addressed effectively. Examining this overlooked aspect of patriotism can provide valuable insights into public perceptions of conflict refugees and inform strategies for mitigating exclusionary rhetoric.

1.2 Research Questions

This paper examines how internal and external factors, along with existing levels of patriotism, shape Projected Patriotism. Internal factors refer to individual attributes such as attachment to symbolic national values and pre-existing levels of blind and constructive patriotism. External factors include military service and political elites' use of refugee-related rhetoric, particularly regarding security, cultural, and economic concerns. I hypothesize that individuals with a strong connection to national symbols will be more inclined toward Projected Patriotism. Additionally, I expect that exposure to refugee-related rhetoric from elites and military service experience will increase Projected Patriotism. Lastly, I predict that blind patriots will be more likely to embrace Projected Patriotism than constructive patriots.

2 Theory

2.1 Internal Factors

Symbols play a powerful role in shaping social, political, and national identities, serving as abstract representations that evoke collective memories, shared values, and cultural narratives Firth (2013). When

individuals connect emotionally with national symbols such as flags, anthems, or colors, this attachment strengthens their loyalty to the nation and influences their sense of duty Butz (2009). This symbolic attachment can extend beyond personal pride, shaping expectations about how others should demonstrate their loyalty. Those who strongly identify with national symbols may assume that citizens of other countries share a similar emotional bond with their own symbols, expecting comparable levels of respect and sacrifice, regardless of differing social or political contexts.

This projection of symbolic attachment is central to Projected Patriotism. Individuals who emphasize traditional symbols and values are more likely to believe that others should demonstrate similar symbolic loyalty. For example, someone who views reverence for their national flag as essential to patriotism may expect citizens of other nations to exhibit the same behavior toward their own flag. This assumption reflects a belief in the universality of symbolic attachment, shaping how individuals evaluate others' loyalty and duty. Consequently, I hypothesize that individuals who express greater attachment to national symbols will demonstrate higher levels of Projected Patriotism.

H₁: National Symbols: *Individuals who state more attachment to national symbols should express a higher level of Projected Patriotism.*

A potential counter-argument to the first hypothesis is that projected patriotism may not be distinct from patriotism itself but rather an extension of broader patriotic tendencies. Since patriotism inherently involves feelings of loyalty, duty, and moral obligation, it is plausible that individuals who strongly identify as patriots may also expect citizens of other countries to demonstrate similar commitments. This overlap highlights the need to distinguish projected patriotism from conventional patriotic attitudes by identifying which forms of patriotism are most relevant in shaping these projected expectations.

To explore this distinction, I focus on Blind and Constructive Patriotism, as these two subtypes are among the most widely studied and provide clear contrasts in patriotic behavior. Blind patriotism reflects an unwavering, idealized loyalty that demands unquestioning support for one's country, often reinforced through strong attachment to national symbols Staub (1991); Huddy and Khatib (2007); Schatz and Staub (1997). In contrast, constructive patriotism emphasizes critical engagement, accountability, and national improvement, encouraging citizens to reflect on and challenge their country's actions when necessary (Schatz and Lavine, 2007). These contrasting attitudes make them particularly relevant for understanding projected patriotism, as individuals who embrace blind patriotism are more likely to assume that others

should display similar unwavering loyalty to their own nations.

Given these distinctions, I hypothesize that individuals who align with Blind Patriotism are more prone to adopt Projected Patriotism than those who identify with Constructive Patriotism. Blind patriots' strong emotional attachment to national symbols and their tendency to expect absolute loyalty make them more inclined to believe that citizens of other nations should mirror this behavior. Conversely, constructive patriots' emphasis on critical reflection makes them less likely to project rigid patriotic expectations onto others. Thus, I predict that projected patriotism will show a stronger correlation with blind patriotism than with constructive patriotism.

H₂: *Projected Patriotism is more correlated with blind patriotism than constructive patriotism.*

2.2 External factors

After developing hypotheses about the internal determinants of Projected Patriotism — particularly attachment to national symbols and the relationship between different forms of patriotism — this section examines external forces that also shape its emergence. Two key external factors warrant attention: first, the role of intergroup interactions, particularly in the context of forced displacement; and second, the influence of economic, cultural, and security-related concerns, which political elites often amplify for political gain. Second, conscription or military service. These factors are particularly relevant in shaping public attitudes and fostering projected patriotism.

Political leaders frequently exploit intergroup resentment to mobilize voter support, particularly in contexts where social or ethnic tensions are heightened. While race-based resentment has been prominent in countries like the United States Knuckey and Kim (2015), resentment toward immigrants, especially refugees, has gained prominence in Europe amid rising populist movements and protest voting Cutts, Ford and Goodwin (2011). This trend intensified following recent refugee crises, as political elites increasingly attributed economic strain and security risks to displaced populations Hernández and Kriesi (2016). Such rhetoric fosters resentment and contributes to the emergence of projected patriotism as a symbolic response to these perceived threats.

Projected patriotism often emerges as a more indirect form of resentment, one that offers psychological and strategic advantages. By framing refugees as insufficiently patriotic, proponents of projected patriotism position themselves as morally superior — as more loyal and deserving citizens. This rhetorical

move shifts blame from broader socio-economic or security concerns onto refugees themselves, reinforcing the notion that displaced individuals are failing to meet national standards of loyalty and responsibility. In this way, projected patriotism allows individuals to express resentment in a way that asserts their own moral standing while justifying their claims to national resources.

Finally, while economic and security debates surrounding refugees remain contested, projected patriotism introduces a moral dimension that is harder to refute. Unlike empirical claims about economic burdens or security risks, accusations that refugees lack patriotism rely on subjective notions of loyalty and national duty. This moral framing not only reinforces negative public perceptions of refugees but also makes counterarguments more difficult to sustain without risking accusations of disloyalty or undermining national pride. Consequently, projected patriotism becomes a potent tool in political discourse, exploiting moral concerns to legitimize resentment while evading empirical scrutiny.

H₃: *Individuals should express a higher level of Projected Patriotism if they are primed with mentions of the general threat or economic/security/cultural issues that potential migrants could cause compared to individuals who are not primed.*

Conscription, or compulsory military enlistment, plays a significant role in shaping individuals' feelings of patriotism. While its effects vary depending on personal experiences and societal context, conscription can foster both positive and negative attitudes toward national loyalty. On the positive side, conscription can instill a sense of duty and obligation, reinforcing the idea that defending the nation is both honorable and necessary. By bringing citizens together in shared military experiences, conscription can also promote national unity and foster strong social bonds across diverse groups.

Additionally, conscription reinforces societal narratives that link patriotism to military service. Individuals who are conscripted, or who grow up in societies with mandatory enlistment, often internalize the belief that military service is a vital aspect of national identity. Even those who are not directly conscripted may feel pressure to uphold these patriotic expectations. This cultural emphasis on military service as a moral responsibility can sustain projected patriotism by framing loyalty and national pride as core values.

Conscription is generally seen as a positive influence on patriotism, provided the process is fair and transparent. Even in countries without mandatory enlistment, voluntary military service still reflects values like duty, sacrifice, and national pride. Individuals with personal or familial ties to the military are often

more likely to adopt projected patriotic attitudes, reinforcing the belief that military service—whether compulsory or voluntary—is a meaningful contribution to the nation’s well-being.

H_{4a}: *Individuals should express a higher level of Projected Patriotism if they are from contexts with conscription compared to respondents who are not from contexts with conscription.*

H₄: *Individuals should express a higher level of Projected Patriotism if they are conscripted or have a family member who served militarily compared to their co-citizens who are not conscripted.*

3 Experimental Design

I conduct survey experiments in Turkey and the United States to analyze determinants of Projected Patriotism. In Turkey, the focus is on Ukrainian refugees fleeing the Russian invasion, while in the United States, the focus is on Central American migrants escaping gang violence. These cases provide valuable insights into how Projected Patriotism is formed and how it influences perceptions of forcibly displaced people. Turkey’s significant refugee population and its proximity to Ukraine make it an ideal case to test the impact of refugee anticipation. Meanwhile, adding the United States allows for variation in the type of conflict driving displacement, enabling a broader understanding of Projected Patriotism’s effects across different contexts.

The experiments examine the determinants of Projected Patriotism and its relationship with other patriotism types. Alongside demographic questions, respondents are asked about their attachment to national symbols, blind patriotism, and constructive patriotism. Respondents are then presented with five vignettes: a control scenario describing refugees or migrants settling in neighboring countries, and four treatments mentioning Turkey (or the US), economic, security, or cultural concerns. These treatments assess whether Projected Patriotism stems from resentment or threat, particularly when amplified by political discourse. For conscription, I compare Turkish and American respondents, as well as Turkish males who either served extended military terms or opted for a shorter paid alternative. Finally, I measure Projected Patriotism using a series of Likert-scale questions to capture key attitudes (see Appendix).

4 Sample

The targeted population in this study is the adult citizens in the United States and Turkey. I aim to recruit 1000 respondents in each country. Prolific will be used to recruit in the United States, and galataanket.com will be used to recruit in Turkey. Respondents who fail attention and manipulation

check questions will be excluded. Given that these checks do not provide a bullet-proof solution, and the respondents have an incentive to rush through questions in online survey experiments, they will also be filtered based on survey duration².

5 Estimation

The treatment effect for elite rhetoric, focusing on the refugee-related issues, is determined using a difference-in-means analysis, which compares the responses of participants exposed to different rhetorical treatments with placebo. The effects of national symbols, military service, and the two patriotism subtypes (blind and constructive patriotism) on projected patriotism are estimated using a multivariate regression model, which takes the following form:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Projected Patriotism} = & \alpha + \beta_1 \textit{Rhetoric} + \beta_2 \textit{Blind} + \beta_3 \textit{Constructive} + \beta_4 \textit{NationalSymbol} \\ & + \beta_5 \textit{controlvariables} + \epsilon \end{aligned}$$

²It is tricky to set cutoff values for duration since outliers, who take extremely long to finish surveys (by leaving the survey open and coming back later etc.) can make it difficult to get reasonable standard deviations. That being said, I plan on using three thresholds based on median duration length.

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